

LIVING WITH THE
GHOST OF SAM

BOOK NINE

FIVE COMEDIANS WALK
INTO A BAR

DEREK DEVON

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To the preachers.

Sam started in a pulpit before he found a stage — and if you've heard both,
you know it was the same act, just a different crowd.

To Brother Bill and everyone still climbing up on Sundays to tell people
it's going to be okay: the world's drowning in the other stuff. Keep going.

Somebody in the back row needs the message more than you know.

THE LIVING WITH THE GHOST OF SAM SERIES

Book One — Living With the Ghost of Sam

Book Two — Night Moves

Book Three — Two Out of Three Ain't Bad

Book Four — Last Laugh

Book Five — Digital Inheritance

Book Six — Missing

Book Seven — Command Performance

Book Eight — The Strange Emergence of Ms. Peel

Book Nine — Five Comedians Walk into a Bar

Book Ten — The Big Shoe, Parts One & Two



CHAPTER ONE

THE LAKE GIVES UP ITS SECRETS (SELECTIVELY)

You never know when life's gonna hit you with the punchline. Sometimes it's a pie in the face. Sometimes it's a Range Rover coming out of a lake with nobody behind the wheel. And sometimes — OH OH OHHHH — it's five dead comedians arguing over who gets the encore. Stick around, kid.
The stones remember, and so do I.

Grey fog lay on Crescent Lake like a blanket somebody's grandmother had crocheted out of secrets. Pre-dawn, two weeks earlier — before any of what follows had a name — the fog carried sound the way fog does, indifferently and forever. Earl and Pete's conversation drifted across the water, two old voices arguing about nothing in particular, and then the morning was split open by a massive SPLASH.

Somewhere in the mist, Pete swam frantically for shore while a section of dock — recently and violently divorced from the rest of the dock — traveled the opposite direction with the serene confidence of a thing that knows where it's going. It crashed into something solid beneath the surface. Something that had no business being there.

The fog kept that detail to itself for two more days.

Then dawn came again, and with it the State Police. Divers slipped into the water while Chief Patterson supervised from shore,

watching the morning sun burn away the last wisps of fog to reveal what the lake had been sitting on: Marina's Range Rover, half-submerged, the broken dock section resting against it like a mourner leaning on a casket.

Martinez approached, tablet in hand. "Found the owner's information. As you suspected, belongs to Marina St. Clair."

"That is who Chad Wellington the Third told us it belonged to," Patterson said. "She is some social media producer, and wife, I believe, of Wellington. He also said that he and St. Clair had tried to buy the old Ravencrest Mansion."

A diver surfaced, gesturing urgently, and whatever comfortable theory Patterson had been assembling died on the spot.

"Chief — no body, but at least three more submerged vehicles are down there. One looks pretty old. But you need to see this."

Three more vehicles. One of them old. In a lake this town had been fishing, swimming, and skinny-dipping in for generations.

Patterson had worked lakes before. Lakes gave up their dead reluctantly but honestly — a lake did not editorialize. This one, he was starting to suspect, had been curating. He looked out at the water, flat and bright and butter-wouldn't-melt innocent, and felt the first cold trickle of a thought he would spend the rest of the week trying to unthink: that the lake had shown them the Range Rover because the lake was done with it.

At that same moment, three hundred miles away in San Francisco General Hospital, a nurse was checking Charles Weber's vitals. Charles Weber — CEO, marketing titan, a man whose idea of chaos was a font change without approval — lay unconscious, machines keeping polite score beside him.

His eyes snapped open. And when he spoke, it was with a delivery the nurse was far too young to place but the universe

recognized instantly.

"OH! OH! OHHHHH! What's with the NEEDLES? If you're trying to sedate me, try an ounce of the white stuff... OH... OH... OHHHHHHHH!"

The nurse dropped her clipboard. Charles blinked, momentarily confused by the shape of his own mouth, then slipped back into unconsciousness — leaving the room to the machines, the clipboard, and a silence that had the distinct texture of an audience waiting for the next bit.

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CHAPTER TWO

BREAKFAST SPECIAL WITH A SIDE OF INTERROGATION

The Last Laugh Diner did its best business on mornings when the town had something to chew on besides Betty's biscuits, and this morning the town had a feast.

News in this town moved by a physics all its own. It did not travel from person to person so much as condense out of the air, so that by seven a.m. everyone from the Buster Keaton Pub's day bartender to the checkout girl at Only Good Liquor knew there was a vehicle in Crescent Lake, knew whose it was, and had formed a settled opinion about the marriage of the people involved.

Chad Wellington III sat at the counter looking like a man who had been dragged backward through his own reflection — dishevelled, frustrated, and radiating the particular misery of a really bad night at the Oceanview Motel. Betty refilled his coffee with professional neutrality while Earl settled onto the next stool and picked up a menu he had memorized during the Clinton administration.

"Morning, Earl. You coming or going to the old fishing hole?"

"Coming, Betty. Came up dry, but enjoyed the show at the lake to pass the time."

"Where's Pete?" She was already filling Earl's cup.

"He's got a small handyman job over at Old Man Rogan's place. Seems his kid sent him some state-of-the-art TV that needs to be mounted and set up so he can watch those MMA shows he loves so much."

The diner's door CHIMED. Chief Patterson entered and removed his sunglasses with the unhurried gravity of a man who had practiced removing sunglasses.

"Wellington. We need to talk about Marina St. Clair."

"Pull up a seat, Chief. I have zero to report on my efforts. The real estate agent denies seeing Marina, and no one in this town seems to have seen anything. Slept like shit last night, to add to this nightmare."

"I can see. Coffee as well, please, miss."

Patterson settled in and recounted what they knew so far, and Chad tensed with every sentence. Earl pretended to be fascinated by his menu. Betty busied herself nearby with a rag and a counter that was already clean. Neither of them missed a word.

"I've been trying to find her the past day and a half," Chad said. "Her phone just goes straight to voicemail. You know where the AirTag points. I know people will say we had a giant fight a few days ago when we stayed at Ravenscrest Mansion — as the videos we posted will show — but I can promise you, she and I made up the next day and were good."

"You know we found her Range Rover in Crescent Lake two days ago," Patterson said, settling onto a stool. "Today we had divers search, and they did not find a body, so my guess is she was never in the vehicle, since the doors were closed. We also have a crane on site and plan to raise and pull it out shortly. You're welcome to come and watch if you want."

Betty, leaning a little too far into her eavesdropping, lost a bowl. It SHATTERED on the floor. Nobody moved to clean it up. The bowl seemed to understand it had become a minor character and lay there quietly.

"I think I will continue to focus my search around the town," Chad said. "I know she was going to visit the real estate agent, Linda Rhodes, who I spoke to, and denies seeing her. I think she is lying to me. You may want to interview her and get your own read."

"I will do that later. But we did find something interesting."

Patterson placed an evidence bag on the counter. Inside: an Oculus X10 headset, its circuits still faintly pulsing with blue light — pulsing, one might note, in a bag, underwater-recovered, connected to no power source anyone could name.

"Looks like one of those new-age VR sets," Chad said. "I am sure I have seen them for sale on TV."

"Saw her heading into the church late Tuesday night, I think." Earl had held out as long as Earl was capable of holding out, which was never long. "Walking kind of funny, like she wasn't quite herself. Well — I think it was a tall white girl with long blonde hair. I think Mrs. Rhodes was with her, but the light was poor, so can't be sure. Plus my eyes are not what they used to be."

Chad and Patterson both turned to him.

"The church?" Patterson said. "You're sure about that?"

"As I said, it was night, and my eyes are not like they used to be — but sure as Pete is still mad about falling off the half-dock into the lake the other day." Earl leaned in conspiratorially. "Though come to think of it... wasn't the first time I've seen folks wearing those fancy goggles around there lately, either."

Three hundred miles away, in a hospital corridor, a doctor was reviewing Charles Weber's brain scans with colleagues, and the corridor's fluorescent hum seemed to lean in and listen. The images showed unusual patterns of activity in the frontal cortex — geometric formations that seemed almost... architectural.

"I've never seen neural pathways structured like this," the doctor said. "It's as if his consciousness is being... rewired from what should be there."

Through the observation window, Charles muttered in his sleep, switching between Don Rickles' rapid-fire delivery and George Carlin's measured cynicism, a one-man festival nobody had booked.

Back in the diner, Chad stood abruptly.

"I need to see that church."

"Mr. Wellington — Chad — this is an active investigation—"

"Sorry, Chief. I have to check this out now, before the trail goes cold."

"That sounds a bit like you have been watching a few too many episodes of Barnaby Jones." It was followed by an uncharacteristic chuckle, the sound of a lawman surprising himself.

Chad turned for the door. "I would prefer to think it is more like Magnum, P.I."

And he was gone. Through the diner's front window, Betty and Earl exchanged the knowing look of people who had watched this town eat confident newcomers for decades.

"Some folks just got to learn the hard way," Earl said to Betty, who was leaning on the counter beside him.

"Can I get the morning breakfast special, please, miss," Patterson said.

Outside, thunder RUMBLED despite the clear sky. The town's weather had long since stopped pretending to be about meteorology.



CHAPTER THREE

THE CRANE AND THE GOGGLES

The E.A. Poe Episcopal Church loomed against the bright sky, its Gothic architecture doing that thing Gothic architecture does — looking simultaneously holy and like it knows where the bodies are. Chad's sports car pulled up alongside several other vehicles, including Linda's Mercedes.

Through the stained glass, movement: robed figures passing in and out of view, unhurried, purposeful, the way people move when they believe the building is on their side.

Chad sat in the car a moment longer than he meant to. He was a man who had built a career on walking into rooms like he owned them — podcasts, pitch meetings, other people's parties — and some animal part of him, older than the brand, was informing him that this particular room owned itself.

In San Francisco, Charles sat upright in his hospital bed, methodically removing his IV with the calm of a man unsubscribing from a newsletter. A nurse tried to stop him.

"Mr. Weber, you need to rest—"

"Rest?" The impression was perfect Jack Nicholson, courtroom snarl and all. "You can't handle the rest!"

He looked briefly confused by his own outburst — then the channel changed, and out came George Burns, dry as the desert:

"You know, I've been in worse hospitals. Course, most of them were asylums..."

Back at Crescent Lake, the crane took up the Range Rover's weight and lifted it slowly from the water. Patterson watched water

cascade from the windows in silver sheets. Martinez approached with a tablet.

"Chief, you need to see this. We got some local security footage that shows the church parking lot."

The footage was grainy, but it was enough. Marina's Range Rover, being driven out of the lot — but not by Marina. The driver's face was obscured; what wasn't obscured was the thing strapped to their head. An Oculus X10. A second angle, from somebody's door camera, caught the Range Rover heading out of town, toward where the trail leads down to the lake.

"What the hell are we dealing with here?" Patterson said. "Are those the same goggles that we found in the car?"

"Chief," Martinez said, "this place is nothing like it appears."

Which was, in this town, roughly the equivalent of announcing that water was wet — but Patterson didn't know that yet. He was still new to the punchline.

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CHAPTER FOUR

THE DOOR OPENS ITSELF

Chad approached the church's main entrance still looking like a mess, which the church appeared to appreciate. Before he could reach for the handle, the door swung open silently on its own.

Linda — Rebecca, to those keeping the older ledger — stood in the doorway, perfectly composed despite the hour.

"Mr. Wellington. Nice to see you again so soon. We've been expecting you."

"I bet you have!"

Behind her, through the church's dim interior, a figure in a hoodie moved quickly between shadows, carrying what looked like computer equipment — and cradled against it, a glowing blue cube, pulsing like a heart that had opinions.

Chad stepped into the shadowy vestibule. Religious artwork lined the walls, and something was off about the paintings — their eyes appeared to follow movement, which is a thing people say about paintings, except these were not being figurative about it.

"I assume you're here about Marina," Linda said. "Chief Patterson called five minutes ago asking me to come to his makeshift command center by the lake for a chat."

"Where is she?"

Linda gestured toward the sanctuary doors. "Perhaps we should discuss this somewhere more... appropriate."

As they walked, Chad noticed modern security cameras disguised as architectural elements — gargoyle here, corbel there — their red lights pulsing in an odd rhythm. The same rhythm, had he

been in a position to compare, as a certain evidence bag on a certain diner counter.

Miles away in the Ravenscrest study, the dumb waiter DINGED, and Nancy retrieved a tray bearing tea, assorted pastries, and two files thick enough to qualify as blunt instruments.

"I think the dumbwaiter thinks it's a librarian today," she told Larry.

"I didn't know there was so much information kept here."

In the mirror, for just a flash — quick enough that a reasonable person could dismiss it, which was exactly the point — there appeared the reflection of Paul Reubens in full character. Pee Wee Herman, watching. Then gone.

And in a San Francisco hospital corridor, Charles walked unsteadily, following some internal compass. A security guard moved to intercept.

"Sir, you need to return to your room—"

"I've been thrown out of better hospitals than this!" Perfect Milton Berle. Then, without missing a beat, Groucho Marx: "Of course, that's not saying much."

He rounded a corner. The sign on the wall read: PSYCHIATRIC WARD.

Somewhere, a certain doctor from a certain cuckoo's nest of a film would have appreciated the symmetry. The ward certainly seemed to.



CHAPTER FIVE

THE GIRL FROM THE TERRA HOYT PODCAST

Linda led Chad past the sanctuary toward a heavy wooden door marked PRIVATE. At the end of the hallway, the hooded figure appeared briefly, then vanished into a shadow with the fluency of someone who had done it many times before.

"What's down there?"

"Storage. Old church records. Nothing of interest."

But Chad was already moving toward where the figure had disappeared down the steps, and for just a moment — one frame in an otherwise flawless performance — Linda's perfect composure slipped.

"Mr. Wellington, that area is—"

Chad pushed past her, opening a door onto stone stairs descending into darkness. From below came the soft HUM of electronics — the sound of the twenty-first century living in the basement of the seventeenth.

Back in the mansion study, Larry was turning a document over in his hands. "Do you and Mr. K think you will eventually figure out what is truly going on here?"

"I hope we can, Larry." Nancy didn't look up from her documents. "I just think that the true secret lies with Doctor Blackwood. Everything seems to emanate from him and his time. That's why it's essential that we figure out his role in all of this."

In the church, Chad descended the stone steps, his phone's flashlight sweeping ancient walls. The electronic hum grew louder

with every step. Above him, Linda remained at the top of the stairs, her silhouette framed against the light like a saint in one of her own suspicious paintings.

"Mr. Wellington, I really must insist—" Though the tone had curdled into something closer to sarcasm, the sound of a woman who knew exactly how this ended and had stopped pretending otherwise.

Chad reached the bottom. His light revealed a startling marriage of centuries — ancient stone walls lined with fiber-optic cables, medieval archways housing modern servers, the whole arrangement humming like a cathedral choir that had gone over to the machines.

He followed the cables into a large chamber, and the chamber made the hallway look quaint. Rows of servers pulsed with the same blue light as the Oculus headset. On multiple screens, surveillance footage cycled through the town — and on screen after screen, townspeople wearing the devices. Ordinary people. Familiar faces. Goggled.

At the central console, the hooded figure turned and lowered her hood.

"What is this place?" Chad demanded. "Where's Marina?"

"You really don't remember me, Chad? The Terra Hoyt podcast?"

He studied her. "The alien hotspot investigation. You were our tech consultant."

"Among other things," Mel said. "Like slipping that AirTag into Marina's purse when you asked me to."

"I never—" Caught. Flat-footed.

"Oh right, that was supposed to be our little secret." Mel's smile did not reach anywhere near her eyes. "Just like February's... special

collaboration."

And then Marina emerged from the shadows — transformed. Her hair was wrong. Her posture was wrong. Her eyes, vacant behind the Oculus device, were the most wrong of all.

The strange thing — the thing Chad would have no time to examine and no capacity to admit — was that his first emotion wasn't fear for her. It was the plummeting, selfish vertigo of a man watching the one audience that had always been contractually obligated to watch him back... change the channel.

"Marina? What happened to your hair... what did they do to you?"

"What did we do to her?" Mel said. "That's rich, coming from the man who's been tracking his wife's every move. Did you really think I wouldn't notice you using my own tech to spy on her?"

"He's always been controlling, Mel." Marina's voice was mechanical, and yet — somehow — more confident than Chad had ever heard it. "That's why I came to you after the mansion incident."

"That's not... I was worried about you!"

"Worried she'd discover your other relationships?" Mel said. "Or worried she'd find out about your real interest in Ravenscrest?"

"Marina, do you know who I am?"

"Babe, darling, I am fantastic." It was almost Marina — the cadence of Marina played back on unfamiliar equipment. "Look at me. I am better than ever."

Chad looked at Mel, then back at his wife. "Marina, please come with me. You don't belong here, and the state troopers are looking for you. Chief Patterson knows I am here, so we better leave now, and we may catch him at the diner."

"Chief Patterson went back to the lake, Chad." Mel let that land. "And Marina is very happy here, and I am sure you will soon be very happy here as well."

Council members in robes emerged from the shadows — each wearing an Oculus headset, each pulsing that same patient blue. Chad backed away, and found that the door behind him had already closed. Doors in this town had a talent for that.

"Don't worry," Mel said. "The transition is relatively painless. Usually."

Marina approached him, arms outstretched, her movements puppet-like. And through her Oculus display flowed geometric patterns — identical, though Chad had no way of knowing it, to the ones blooming across Charles Weber's brain scans three hundred miles away.



CHAPTER SIX

ACCESS GRANTED

In the psychiatric ward, Charles had found a computer terminal, and the computer terminal was having the worst day of its professional life.

The security guard spoke into his walkie-talkie while Charles's fingers flew across the keyboard, his voice shifting between comedians like a radio being tuned by a poltergeist.

"Mr. Weber is here at the psych desk and he's trying to play with the computer. He seems out of it to me. Please advise what you want me to do."

The walkie-talkie crackled back: "He's probably having a psychotic episode. He can't get into the computer system, so just hang tight and we will send an orderly to deal with him properly."

The system, for the record, disagreed.

"I tell ya, these hospital computers get no respect—" Rodney.

"Man, this firewall's about as useful as a screen door on a submarine—" Pryor.

"OH OH OHHHH! Access GRANTED!" And that one needed no introduction.

The screen bloomed with schematics. The Oculus X10, rendered in exploded technical detail — bearing, in the corner, the logo of Blackwood Industries.

In the church basement, Larry's voice carried on in the mansion study, which is to say the story folded the two rooms against each other the way this town's story insisted on doing.

"Take a look at this early drawing made by Blackwood," Larry said. "It's dated 1961. Look familiar to you?"

Nancy took the document. "Wow, Larry. How did Blackwood come up with the idea of a headset before the personal computer was even built? I am sure the first desktops did not hit the market until the late seventies. I think even Bill Gates or Steve Jobs were still in grade school back then."

Larry was holding Nancy's Sherlock Holmes dumbwaiter magnifying glass. "Look at the upper left corner. I think it says 'Area51 — Restricted Access' on that door."

Nancy took the glass, looked at the corner, and turned to Larry with an expression that had abandoned all pretense of calm.

Below the church, Marina kept coming, her movements growing more fluid — almost predatory. Chad's back found the door.

"Look, Mel, whatever you're doing here, it's going to come out. You can't just make people disappear."

"Disappear? Oh, Chad, we're not making anyone disappear. We're making them better. More connected. Like your friend Charles."

"Who's Charles? What does this Charles have to do with this?"

Mel adjusted something on her console, and the screens filled with hospital surveillance footage — Charles Weber, cycling through dead men's voices, hacking a terminal he should not have been able to touch.

"Let's just say he got an early preview of what's coming. Though his... transition has been less controlled than we'd like. That's why we developed version 2.0."

She said it the way engineers everywhere discuss a failed build — no malice, no apology, just the flat conviction that the problem was in the release, never the roadmap. Somehow that was worse

than cruelty. Cruelty could be argued with.

In the hospital, Charles stared at the schematics, hands trembling, as a security guard and an orderly approached with the caution of men cornering a raccoon in a suit.

"Hi, Mr. Weber. Time to go to your new room."

"The numbers, Mason... what do they mean?" The voices came fast now, sliding off each other. "OH OH OHHHH! You can't handle the truth about these numbers! I get no respect, no respect at all from these algorithms..."

The orderly, with the guard's help, slid a needle into his arm. Charles slowly went slack, and they eased him into a wheelchair. As they wheeled him away down the long fluorescent hall, his lips moved one more time — faint, almost fond, from somewhere deep in the ward's collective memory:

"...Juicy Fruit."

Nobody caught it. The ward did.

And in the basement, Marina reached for Chad with another headset while the robed figures closed in, their devices pulsing in synchronized rhythm.

"Join us, Chad," Marina said. "Remember how good it felt that night in February? This is so much better."

"You're going to love being part of something bigger than your pathetic little podcasts and social media stunts," Mel said. "We're building a network. A consciousness that spans beyond just this town. You are going to lead the way for everyone. The stones remember, Chad."

Chad shoved Marina backward, turned, and ran — across the room to a far door. The handle turned. He plunged through into a hallway, then down another set of stairs, hoping against the available evidence that it led to an exit. His phone light snapped on,

and the walls it found were less hallway and more something older.
Some ancient tunnel. A catacomb system that had been waiting
under the church, patient as stone.

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CHAPTER SEVEN

PATIENT WARD B

Chad's phone light swept ancient stone corridors, and the corridors swept back. The walls bore the same geometric patterns as the mansion — but darker somehow, their design more aggressive, geometry with its teeth showing.

"Come on," he whispered to himself, "there's got to be a way out..."

His light caught something metal. An old brass nameplate:

PATIENT WARD B — EXPERIMENTAL CONSCIOUSNESS
THERAPY

He followed the corridor into a large chamber, and the chamber told him everything he did not want to know. Ancient hospital beds lined the walls, their metal frames wrapped in the same geometric patterns as the church architecture above. Old medical equipment sat under decades of dust. A metal plate attached to one machine read: PROPERTY OF US AIR FORCE.

"What the hell is this place?" he said, examining a bed.

His light found a leather restraint hanging from the frame. The metal buckle was engraved:

BLACKWOOD INDUSTRIES — 1947

Nineteen forty-seven. The number sat there in the brass, patient as everything else down here, and Chad felt the timeline of his understanding quietly break. Whatever was happening in the server room above wasn't new. It wasn't tech-bro disruption or a cult with good funding. It was the latest release of something that had been in development since before television — and these beds, with their

restraints and their dust, were the beta program.

Up in the psychiatric ward, Charles sat pretending to type on an imaginary keyboard, his voices shifting rapidly.

"OH OH OHHHH! The code... it's all connected!"

"Hey, these algorithms are tougher than my mother-in-law, and that's saying something!"

At the nurses' station, two doctors and a nurse observed the performance.

"Let's do some more blood work," the doctor said, "and we need an up-to-date CAT scan. I want to see what's going on in his frontal cortex."

Below the church, Chad checked his phone's battery. Fifty-three percent. He dimmed the light to preserve it — and in the lowered glow, the walls revealed something the brightness had hidden: a strange blue phosphorescence living inside the geometric patterns, faint and patient.

"No, no, no... this can't be happening to me..." His voice cracked on the injustice of it. "I am too important... successful..."

He spotted a small alcove holding what appeared to be an ancient cot. Exhausted past the point of judgment, he sat.

Some part of him understood that sitting was a mistake — that the tunnels had been herding him toward this alcove the way a house herds a draft toward a door. But exhaustion has its own eloquence, and the cot made its case better than the fear did.

"Just... need to rest. Figure this out..."

He switched off the phone light, and as his eyes closed, the patterns on the walls pulsed gently. Almost soothingly.

Almost like a lullaby that knew his name.



CHAPTER EIGHT

A BEAUTIFUL DAY IN THIS STUDY

Two days later, the Ravenscrest library had been converted into a war room, if wars were fought with newspaper clippings and architectural drawings. Nancy pored over old town records; every surface had surrendered to paper.

"1947," she read aloud. "Blackwood Industries acquires former asylum for 'innovative consciousness research'... Blackwood Industries hired to work with US Air Force on July 8, 1947 — Roswell crash."

"Miss Nancy, if you don't need me for anything else, I should get back to the basement and continue my testing."

"Okay, Larry. Thanks for your help carrying all those books and papers."

Larry departed, and Nancy crossed to the mansion intercom. "Smithers, are you available?"

In the large mirror — unobserved, which was how it preferred to work — an image had assembled itself: Tim Conway as the dentist from an old Carol Burnett sketch, watching Nancy with that trembling, glacial patience. Then the image switched. Pee Wee Herman now, full makeup, the original grey suit.

He sang — softly, to the tune every American child of a certain era knew by heart, but with an evil little curl on it:

"It's a beautiful day in this Study, a beautiful day for a neighbor. Would you be mine? Could you be mine?"

"Yes, Miss Nancy." Smithers appeared at the door literally as the word "available" left her mouth — a punctuality that had long since

stopped being explicable. "I just happened to be coming here to bring you these files that I found in the room off of the kitchen pantry."

"Look at this headline, Smithers. Do you know anything about this event, or how Blackwood Industries got involved?"

She watched his face as she asked it. Smithers' face was, as ever, a masterpiece of butlerly composure — but Nancy had spent months learning to read the man the way Larry read gauges, and there it was: a flicker, gone in half a second, of someone deciding how much of the truth the room could hold.

In the mirror behind them, Pee Wee changed back into Conway's dentist and turned and shuffled out of the reflection with that tiny, maddening, half-inch-at-a-time gait — an exit that took a small eternity and was clearly enjoyed by all parties involved, all parties being him.

At San Francisco General, Charles stood at a window, speaking into a smuggled phone — and for once, the voice was entirely his own.

"Yes, I had some sort of psychotic event the other day. I don't remember anything, but the doctors said they think it was brought on by stress, and perhaps an allergic reaction to the Halon gas. They want to keep me a few more days for observation, but I should be back to work Monday. Get a hold of Kinison ASAP and tell him to get his butt back here next week for a couple days. Don't mention my hospital visit, either."

He stared out the window as he spoke. And in the glass, where his reflection should have been, was a different image: a man in a strange robe, standing where Charles stood, holding the phone Charles held.

Across the room, the television screen flickered — and through it, AISAM watched with an expression no algorithm should have

been able to render. Concern.

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CHAPTER NINE

THE STONES REMEMBER

Chad woke with a scream.

His phone was dead. But the walls' phosphorescence had grown stronger while he slept, strong enough to see by — and in that dim blue light, he saw something carved into the stone beside his cot. Fresh marks. Marks that had not been there before:

THE STONES REMEMBER

He had been down here two days now, dishevelled, unshaven, disoriented — long enough that the tunnels had stopped being a maze and started being a residence.

"I have to get some water. I need to go home, to my own bed. I need Marina."

He began to retrace his route back toward the basement antechamber, no longer caring who was there to greet him. That was the thing about the catacombs. They didn't break you. They just waited while you did it yourself.

Thunder RUMBLED above — above, despite his being deep underground. The geometric patterns pulsed with increasing intensity, and Chad stumbled on through the phosphorescent tunnels, clothes dusty, face raw.

"Marina..." His voice was hoarse gravel. "I'm coming..."

He emerged into a larger chamber where ancient medical equipment glowed with the same blue energy as the Oculus devices, machinery from 1947 humming along to a song written yesterday.

That Sunday afternoon, in San Francisco, Charles Weber signed his discharge papers with movements that were precise and

controlled. No comedian voices. Just cold efficiency, boxed and shipped.

"Mr. Weber, are you sure you feel ready—"

"Perfectly fine. Just needed a reset." A slight smile. "Time to get back to work."

"I want to have a follow-up with you in two weeks to review your CAT scans. Nothing to be alarmed about, but we need to discuss them. Here is a prescription I want you to take twice daily until we meet."

Charles took the prescription and walked out. In the window's reflection as he passed, he was wearing an Oculus device — though there was nothing on his actual head. At the hospital's front door, without breaking stride, he tossed the prescription into a garbage can.

Beneath the church, Chad reached the stairs to the main basement. The HUM of the servers swelled. He climbed, and entered the room.

"Welcome back, Chad." Mel's voice echoed from everywhere and nowhere. "We missed you. I bet you would love a glass of Chardonnay, and maybe some Grey Poupon on rye with a side of shaved pastrami? Or would you prefer some caviar with a fine French stick?"

"I need water. Just some water." He slumped into a chair against the wall, a man with nothing left to negotiate with.

"Oh, Chaddy, you look absolutely parched." Marina glided toward him. "Here, put on this headset for me, and I will get you a bottle of water."

He didn't fight it. That was the detail the room's cameras would preserve: after two days in the dark, Chad Wellington III tilted his head forward to make it easier, the way a man leans into a barber's

chair.

Everyone in the room watched as Marina slipped the headset onto Chad's head. Within fifteen seconds, he began to sit up in his chair — spine straightening, misery draining away like it had somewhere better to be. Whatever the show was, it had excellent production values.

"Chad, why don't you relax while Marina fetches you a bottle of water," Mel said. "Please enjoy the show. It's specially just for you."

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CHAPTER TEN

EVERY MIRROR IN THE HOUSE

In the Ravencrest study, the present day arrived like a thrown brick.

"The quantum field..." Larry was checking readings frantically. "The mansion's defences are failing! The protection protocols—"

"Not failing, kid." AISAM's voice. "Evolving."

In the smallest mirror on the wall, a quick glimpse: Pee Wee Herman, laughing, jumping up and down with delight at absolutely nobody's expense but everyone's.

"You don't wanna get mixed up with a guy like me. I'm a loner, a rebel."

Nancy turned and caught the image looking directly at her. "Pee Wee?"

"That's my name. Don't wear it out." And he began to fade away, giggling into the silver.

Then, without warning, every mirror in the room SHATTERED simultaneously.

Through the fragments — each shard holding its own sliver of picture — they glimpsed multiple realities overlapping: past experiments, future possibilities, roads not taken. And threaded through all of them, Pee Wee, laughing at them.

The sound was extraordinary — not a crash but a chord, a hundred silvered surfaces letting go at once, as if the house had been holding its breath since 1947 and finally exhaled through every reflection it owned.

Derek was across the room and at Nancy's side before the glass finished falling, checking her for cuts. "Nancy, the surveillance cameras—"

"Already transmitting. But Derek... I don't think we were the only ones watching."

The pipe organ began playing an impossible chord — notes that should not have coexisted, creating harmony out of chaos. It sounded almost reversed, like the sound was being played backwards, the way they used to claim about that Beatles album with its hidden message. The mansion's geometric patterns pulsed in response, every line of the old house answering.

Smithers calmly adjusted his bow tie. "I believe, Master Kinison, we're about to discover exactly why your uncle chose this particular venue for his final performance."

Thunder CRASHED, and the energy patterns between church and mansion aligned perfectly — a circuit closing around the entire town. Through the mathematical chaos came Sam's legendary laugh. But it was different now. Layered. Other voices inside it, other consciousnesses riding along.

"OH OH OHHHH!" Sam and Jonathan and AISAM, voices merged into a single impossible chord of their own. "Ready for the encore, kid?"

Above the mansion's roof, had anyone been in a position to see it, the entire town now glowed with geometric patterns — two quantum consciousness networks battling for control. Order versus chaos. Protection versus liberation. Memory versus forgetting. Good versus evil.

Far from the light, on a rise where the whole glowing town lay spread out below like a circuit diagram, gloved hands adjusted a small brass instrument and made a single notation in a weathered notebook. Whoever it was did not seem surprised. They had, the

stillness of them suggested, been expecting this exact night for a very long time — and they watched the two patterns wrestle across the rooftops the way a patient examiner watches a proof approach its final line.

Then the hands closed the notebook, and the rise was empty.

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CHAPTER ELEVEN

CHOCOLATE-COVERED STRAWBERRIES AT MIDNIGHT

Late that night, Derek and Nancy lay in bed while moonlight filtered through the Victorian windows and the mansion's geometric patterns pulsed softly — almost like a lullaby, and unlike the ones under the church, this lullaby meant it kindly.

That was the part nobody tells you about living in a haunted mansion during a quantum war: life keeps insisting on itself. Somewhere across town a man was strapped to a bed from 1947, two consciousness networks were arm-wrestling over the municipal grid — and here, in this room, a wife wanted to talk about skinny dipping. The mansion, to its credit, considered this the correct set of priorities.

Nancy traced patterns on Derek's chest. "Remember the time at your grampa's cottage? When we took the old Joey 'B' over to that bay and went skinny dipping?"

"You mean where the canoeist got an unexpected eyeful when we emerged from the boat's cuddy cabin, with me in full form... naked?"

She laughed, snuggling closer. "I have been having dreams almost every night of those old days. Smithers tells me I am doing some internal reset. But I am beginning to think it's something different."

Derek, attempting to restart certain proceedings, went to suckle her earlobe. "What?"

"I was thinking earlier... about what you said when we first saw this place. About feeling alive again."

He lifted his head, releasing the earlobe with visible regret. "Even with evil quantum networks and possessed social media influencers?"

"Especially then." Playful now. "Besides, how many wives get to say their husband's haunted mansion makes them breakfast? I love that we are excited again!"

"I can't help it. You're just so beautiful."

"I don't mean that, funny boy. I mean this—" And she was out of bed with nothing on, framed in moonlight. "Race you to the kitchen for some ice cream!"

"Dressed — or I guess, more accurate, non-dressed — we are surely going to create some quantum entanglement for the kids," Derek said, hopping out of bed and slipping into his Big Foot slippers, which remained the least dignified footwear ever to participate in a supernatural crisis.

The dumb waiter DINGED softly.

"Speaking of..." Derek checked inside. "Chocolate-covered strawberries? At midnight?"

"I believe the mansion thought you might need... sustenance before tomorrow's big day." Smithers' voice, from the hallway, with impeccable timing as ever.

"Thank you, Smithers!" Nancy called out.

"Does he ever sleep?"

Through their bedroom mirror, Sam appeared — adjusting his beret with the care of a man who had exactly one item of wardrobe and knew its value.

"Sleep is for people who don't have an evil church trying to steal their consciousness! OH OH OHHHH!"

AISAM appeared in the mirror beside him. "You know what they say, brother... three Kinisons are better than a thousand Dice Clays."

Derek and Nancy retired back to the bed with the tray from the dumbwaiter, the ice cream race abandoned to a superior offer.

"I'm starting to understand why you Kinison men are so loud," Nancy said.

Derek fed her a strawberry and got chocolate on her nose.

"You know what this reminds me of?"

"What?"

"The night you came over to my house before I left for university, and you said... 'I think I am falling in love with you...'"

"Why that memory?"

"It was the moment I first knew, subconsciously, that I was destined to marry you."

Thunder RUMBLED — playfully, if thunder can be said to do such a thing, and in this house it could. Through various reflective surfaces around the room, their "children" watched like proud parents:

"I tell ya, these kids got better moves than my first marriage!" Rodney's reflection crowed. "And my second! And my—"

"Oh, grow up!" Joan Rivers' reflection cut in. "They're cuter than my last facelift — and trust me, that was EXPENSIVE!"

"How does he stay at full mast so long?" Gilda Radner marveled. "I was lucky to get my guy to find half-mast."

Nancy threw a pillow at the mirror. The reflections scattered, laughing.

Then she grew serious. "Charles is coming back for the show."

"I know. And whatever's happening at the church... it's going to get stronger."

"The council's going to expect your perfect performance tomorrow."

Derek pulled her close. "Good thing I've got the best stage manager in town."

The pipe organ began to play "The Way You Look Tonight," drifting up through the floorboards like the house's own opinion on the matter.

"Just promise me one thing?"

"Anything."

"When this is all over... can we get a normal house? One without quantum networks and ghost comedians and—"

Every mirror in the room suddenly filled with their spectral audience, shouting in unison:

"NO!"

Derek and Nancy burst out laughing. Through the window, the geometric patterns between church and mansion pulsed like competing heartbeats.

"What about all that talk about finding our energy again..." Derek began.

"You mean this energy?" And she dove under the covers.

"Get some rest, kids," said Sam and AISAM together, from everywhere and nowhere at once. "The real show's about to begin..."



CHAPTER TWELVE

ENJOY THE SHOW

Beneath the E.A. Poe Episcopal Church, the lab hummed on through the night.

At the central console, Mel sat having a pleasant chat with the figure on her computer monitor — grey suit, red bowtie, that laugh. Pee Wee Herman, rendered in pixels and perfectly at home there, as though a screen were just one more mirror with better bandwidth.

Whatever they were discussing, it was going well. Mel laughed at something. The figure on the screen laughed back, longer, and kept laughing a beat past where a person would have stopped.

And on the far side of the room, on one of the old beds, lay Chad Wellington III — headset on, strapped down at wrist and ankle by leather restraints whose buckles had been engraved before his grandfather was born.

Marina stood over him, a small device in her hand. Every few seconds, with the placid diligence of a woman watering a houseplant, she pressed its button. Chad's body jumped against the straps each time, a marionette getting notes from a new director.

She did not look troubled. She looked, if anything, better than ever.

The blue light pulsed. The stones remembered.

Fade to black, kid. That's not the end — that's just the house lights coming down. The real show's tomorrow night, and between you and me?

Somebody down in that basement bought a ticket they can't afford. OH

OH OHHHH...

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LAST CALL

After the story ends, one mirror stays lit. In it, a man stands alone, deadpan, looking straight out at whoever's still in their seat. Norm Macdonald was always the last one comfortable with silence.

"So, five comedians go into a bar. The bartender says, can I help you. The first comedian says, 'We are five comedians, and we think we can make this bar some money.' The bartender says, I agree — grab a seat, and what can I get you to drink? The second comedian says, I will have a Harvey Wallbanger. The third comedian says, get me a double scotch. The fourth comedian says, I want a Blow Job, and your best tequila on the rocks. The fifth comedian says, I will take a pint of your best stout. And the first comedian says, I would love a Smerconish Manhattan, extra pink stuff. The bartender comes back and gives the drinks to the comedians. The third comedian says to the bartender: aren't you interested in how we are going to make you money? The bartender says, no, I already know — and hands them a bill for their drinks.

"What, you thought I was going to tell that stupid frog joke again?

"...Herman, I think this is your crowd."

And the credits roll — each name shoved into view by Pee Wee Herman himself, pushing the text boxes like furniture, doing what Pee Wee Herman always does: being silly, forever, for free.

END OF BOOK NINE

ABOUT THE AUTHOR



Derek Devon is the pen name of a first-time novelist who spent a long career in the corporate world before deciding the stories rattling around his head deserved better than PowerPoint. He is the author of the seventeen-book science fiction series *The Last Axiom* and the debut novel *A Letter Guide for Rebecca*.

Living With the Ghost of Sam is his love letter to the golden age of stand-up comedy, to old houses with opinions, and to everyone who ever lost someone and kept the conversation going.

He lives in Florida, where the thunder is frequent and, he insists, occasionally well-timed.

ALSO BY DEREK DEVON

The Last Axiom (Books 1–15)

A Letter Guide for Rebecca